

A part of the network

Despite the several lines within Assam, the network remained detached from the rest of British India. The Government knew that the advantages of linking Assam were not just commercial, but also strategic. Engineer-in-Chief JW Buyers, based on his surveys, recommended that two separate lines be built – for the Surma Valley in south-eastern Bengal and the Brahmaputra Valley—which would connect at the North Cachar Hills (in the present-day district of Dima Hasao). Chittagong (in modern-day Bangladesh) was chosen as the preferred port for the line that would end in Gauhati (Guwahati).

The Assam Bengal Railway was incorporated in March 1892 and construction started along the three main sections of the 1,190-km-long line. The Chittagong to Badarpur (and the Badarpur–Silchar) section, completed in 1899, ran about 487 km. The third section from Lumding to Makum, which also joined Tinsukia, up to Gauhati, wrapped up work by 1903. For the first time, a part of the northeast was inextricably linked to the rest of India by the rail network.

The notorious hill section

Work on the third section, Lumding–Badarpur, began after fresh surveys in 1896 and Haflong, sitting at an elevation of 730 m, became the headquarters for the operations. It took almost 11 years for the workers and engineers to build a line through the North Cachar Hills as not all their previous learnings from building hill railways could be used here. The 1908 *Imperial Gazetteer* noted that the terrain proved most challenging as it ran through “shale of the worst description, often intermixed with bands of kaolinite, which swells when exposed and causes heavy slips, or exerts immense pressure on the sides of tunnels.”

The earthwork involved was massive and tunnelling, which required the expertise of Cornish miners, was no mean feat. The 181-km section had 24 tunnels, seven covered ways, and 74 major bridges, the longest being 198 m and the highest, 34 m above the river bed. The line opened in 1903 and Lord Curzon, Viceroy of India (1899–1905), inaugurated the entire system in 1904 calling it “one of the costliest and most difficult railway enterprises that have ever been undertaken in India.” The trials